

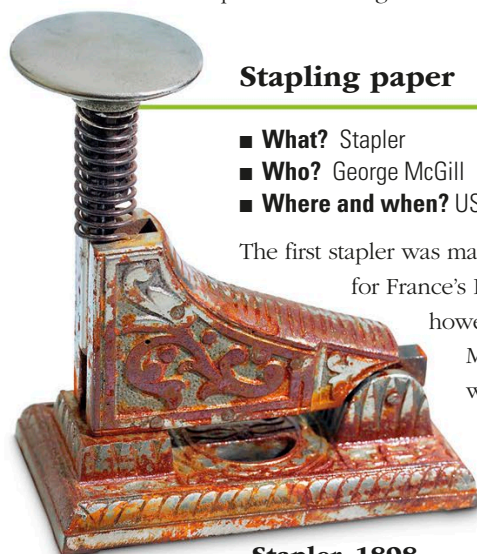
At the office

Modern offices run with help from large inventions such as photocopiers and computers, but are also full of smaller inventions that people rarely think about. From handy erasers to number-crunching calculators, office workers depend on these clever gadgets.

Sharpening pencils

- **What?** Pencil sharpener
- **Who?** Thierry Des Estivaux
- **Where and when?** France, 1847

Although the lead pencil dates back to the 16th century, it took two more centuries for a practical sharpener. Bernard Lassimone from France invented the first sharpener in 1828, but it was not until 1847 when Frenchman Thierry des Estivaux patented his design of the classic sharpener still recognizable today.



Stapling paper

- **What?** Stapler
- **Who?** George McGill
- **Where and when?** US, 1866

The first stapler was made in the 18th century for France's King Louis XV. In 1866, however, American George McGill patented what we would today recognize as a stapler. A few years later, patents were made by other inventors in the US and UK.

Stapler, 1898

Securing documents

- **What?** Paper clip
- **Who?** Gem Manufacturing Company
- **Where and when?** UK, 1890s

Living in Germany, the Norwegian Johan Vaaler was an inventor who, in 1899, received the first patent for a paper clip. However, the improved paper clip we know and use today was developed by the Gem Manufacturing Company.



Desk-mounted sharpener

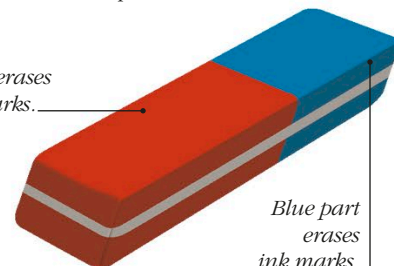


Erasing mistakes

- **What?** Pencil eraser
- **Who?** Joseph Priestley
- **Where and when?** UK, 1770

In 1770, the philosopher, theologian, and chemist Joseph Priestly discovered that rubber wiped the pencil marks from paper. However, it was English engineer Edward Nairne who developed the idea and marketed the first rubber eraser in Europe.

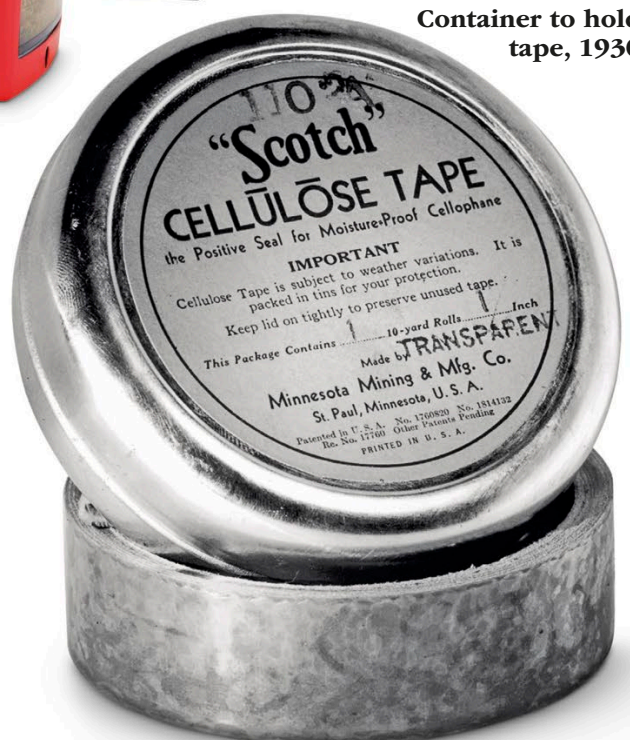
Red part erases pencil marks.



Blue part erases ink marks.

Modern eraser

Handle is rotated to sharpen pencil.



Container to hold tape, 1930

Sticking objects together

- **What?** Clear adhesive tape
- **Who?** Richard Drew
- **Where and when?** US, 1930

In 1925, American inventor Richard Drew—an employee

of the 3M Company—created a clear, sticky tape to help make straight lines when painting cars. Five years later, it was marketed as an all-purpose adhesive tape.